

Gianna Leidich

Professor Phan

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The Instability of Cultural Symbols as in *The Scarlet Letter*

In Nathaniel Hawthorne's *The Scarlet Letter*, main character Hester Prynne is sentenced to wear a bold letter A—the *scarlet letter*—on her chest as a punishment for her sin. This sentencing is meant to clearly label Hester sinner and outcast her from the other members of the Puritan community in which she lives. In the beginning of the novel, the scarlet letter is treated with its original meaning as members of the community avoid and shun Hester for her marked wickedness and wrongdoings. Yet as the novel progresses, the scarlet letter begins to lose its original meaning; it becomes less a symbol of sin than something that is simply accepted and seen as “normal”. This transformation occurs in conjunction with Hester's reintegration into the community as members begin to re-embrace her after witnessing her repeated kindness and altruism. In their eyes, she has redeemed herself, and has diverged from the sinful figure painted by her reputation so much that no longer could they associate the symbol's original meaning with Hester. As public opinion on Hester changed, so did the meaning of the scarlet letter. *The Scarlet Letter* demonstrates how cultural symbols are subject to change over time, influenced by how members of the community in which those symbols live change along with them. Furthermore, the meaning of the cultural symbols depend on the context in which they are viewed—in the novel, outsiders who are not aware of the community's history, religious beliefs, and attitudes toward Hester do not view the scarlet letter with its original interpretation, and

instead view it with their own. So even as the meaning of a symbol changes internally, however an outsider views it may be unaffected by that change.

In the beginning of the main story, Hester is condemned to wear the scarlet letter, which is originally intended to be a “mark of shame upon her bosom” that she must keep on for the “rest of her natural life” (Hawthorne 46). She first appears wearing the scarlet letter in front of a crowded market square, where members of the community eagerly await to see her and learn of her punishment. Most know of Hester’s sin, and are unhappy and unimpressed with it, due to the extremely pious nature of the community: ““This woman has brought shame upon us all, and ought to die’” (38). Since the townspeople look upon Hester with shame and contempt, they view the scarlet letter with its original meaning: to shame and outcast Hester. Thus, how the community views the scarlet letter is a reflection of how they view Hester. As a result, Hester is alienated immediately after her sentencing: “there was nothing [about her community] that made her feel as if she belonged to it... [she was] as much alone as if she inhabited another sphere” (58). She is isolated because no one dared to befriend her, a sinner and outcast, following the sentencing. Even children learn to avoid her and acquire a “strange contagious fear” when they see Hester and the scarlet letter on her breast (57). This demonstrates how cultural symbols persist in a community by their meaning being passed on through the generations. The children learn from the townspeople to cease to view Hester as a person, and instead for the deeds she has committed. When people see her, they first see the scarlet letter on breast, and then the person underneath. Hester becomes so synonymous with the scarlet letter that she *herself* becomes a symbol:

“Throughout them all, giving up her individuality, she would become the general symbol at which the preacher and moralist might point, and in which they might vivify and embody their images of woman’s frailty and sinful passion” (55).

The community views Hester and the scarlet letter as one to such an extent that the line between person and symbol has blurred beyond recognition. The two cannot be differentiated. As one changes, so must the other, and either can affect the other. Therefore, how people view the symbol informs how they view Hester, and vice-versa; that is, public opinion on one reflects on the other. At this point in the story, Hester’s sin is still fresh in the minds of the townspeople, so people associate her, and therefore the symbol, with sin—the original intention.

The original meaning of the scarlet letter begins to dissipate midway through the novel. It is established early-on that Hester is a very charitable woman, and is overall good-natured and caring. In the beginning, when she and the scarlet letter are both viewed in contempt “the poor [...] often reviled the hand that was stretched forth to succor them” (59). Hester’s reputation is so terrible that even those she was trying to help would view her sourly. This shows how much a cultural symbol can influence the society in which it lives—the poor saw and understood the symbol, the wickedness it represented, and so saw that in Hester *despite* her help and charity. The poor put more stock in the intended meaning of the scarlet letter and what it said about Hester than what Hester’s actual actions demonstrated about her personality. Hester only slowly becomes reintegrated into the community through her repeated good deeds, and that she committed no further offenses. For example, Hester “never battled with the public” in trying to change their opinion of her, and continued to help the poor “even as the bitter-hearted pauper threw back in a gibe” (108). When people started to recognize Hester’s repeated altruism and

benevolence, they also started to view her more favorably, to the point that “many people refused to interpret the scarlet A by its original signification” (108). Because the townspeople’s opinions of Hester changed over time, so did their interpretation of the scarlet letter, with the new interpretation reflecting the more positive public opinion of Hester. When the community members re-embrace Hester, they also “embrace” the symbol—not as something to be looked at and scorned, but instead to be accepted and reinterpreted to fit present-day public opinion. Some even saw it as akin to “the cross on a nun’s bosom” due to the *goodness* it now represents (109). Since the townspeople saw Hester and the scarlet letter as one, when Hester’s goodness changed their opinions on her, it simultaneously changed their opinion on the symbol to now reflect that goodness. The scarlet letter ceased being a stamp of sin and took on the new meaning of being a token of goodness, demonstrating how even symbols with dramatic meanings are never completely concrete.

When Hester first starts wearing the scarlet letter, she dreads newcomers who come to the community, because when they first look curiously at the scarlet letter, they “branded it afresh in Hester’s soul” (59). The curiosity and intensive stares of outsiders remind Hester of the scarlet letter’s existence, especially when compared to that of the townspeople who view it with familiarity. She fears she will have to suffer under their scrutiny in addition to the scrutiny she already faces from the townspeople, but in the eyes of newcomers, the scarlet letter is strange and alien—but not always *bad*. For example, a bond-servant of the Governor’s “being a newcomer in the country” had “never seen” the scarlet letter before, and so did not have the prior knowledge of the events that led to its existence. He came to his own conclusion: that Hester was a “great lady in the land” and that the symbol labeled her as so (71). To outsiders who are unaware of a symbol’s meaning to a community and the history behind it, the symbol is then up

to their own interpretation, based on their own life experiences. Thus cultural symbols integral to one community may not be understood or clear to those outside of that community. Furthermore, the way that outsiders are formally introduced to cultural symbols are influenced by members of the community. If their interpretations of the symbols change, they will relate that new interpretation to outsiders, rather than the old one. The evolution of a symbol over time is driven by how both insiders and outsiders view that symbol, and the internal and external changes to the community in which it exists.

The scarlet letter's meaning changed as the community's opinion on Hester did the same, showing that cultural symbols and what they represent are subject to change over time. How we interpret cultural symbols in the present can be drastically different from their original interpretations and intended meanings because humans naturally change and evolve, and will perceive things differently in the present than in the past. This is also shown in "The Custom-House"—the very introduction of the novel—which takes place long before the events of the main story. When the narrator first introduces the scarlet letter, he describes its beauty, and the intricacy of its embroidery (27). The narrator proceeds to imply that the scarlet letter could be a symbol of art and beauty—a whole departure from the original intention—showing how cultural symbols truly change meaning over time, and how their interpretation is dependent on the context in which it is viewed. We can therefore use cultural symbols to give us an insight into the past, and use how they changed over time to analyze how humans changed along with them. We might also consider the cultural symbols we hold in the present, how they might change, and how that change might reflect back on us—people in the future may also "refuse to interpret" our symbols with their "original significations" as well (108).

Works Cited

Hawthorne, Nathaniel. *The Scarlet Letter*. Nathaniel Hawthorne Classics, 2023.